‘Whatever you tell me to do, I’ll do.’

I didn’t want to be in Japan as a cheerleader. I knew that the United trainers would give me all the help I needed. The work was down to me: resting my foot and keeping weight off it for a month or so but there was plenty I could still do to help cut down on the time I’d need to get myself ready for soccer again once the broken bone had healed. I’d be in at Carrington for as long as the trainers thought was worthwhile. When I’m injured—and now was no different—I’ll always be ready to push myself as hard as I can to give myself a better chance. On my days off, Terry Byrne would come over to the house and keep an eye on me while I did extra rehab. I could do running in the deep end of my pool, making sure my foot didn’t touch the bottom. I could work on my overall fitness in the gym. The World Cup was all the motivation I needed, however fed up I was with the routine of working on all those machines.

Usually, a player’s left with the day-to-day progress of an injury to deal with on his own. During that April and May, though, it seemed like there were a few million England supporters looking over my shoulder, having the same worries as I was. The fans’ good wishes helped me along. Gary Neville was there for me too: he phoned as soon as he got away from Old Trafford after the La Coruña game. A fortnight later, I was watching the first leg of the Champions League semi-final against Bayer Leverkusen on television, the night he picked up the same injury. The moment Gary went down I knew what had happened. And I knew that, if I was touch and go for the World Cup, Gary had no chance. He just didn’t have time. If I’d been him, I would have been devastated. But Gaz is so positive in his attitude: whatever he was feeling inside, he did his best to stay upbeat. He deserved better than to have to miss three months of the following season as well because the foot needed an operation to put things right.

I was worried about the summer and I was really disappointed to miss the end of United’s season. Bayer Leverkusen put us out of the Champions League on away goals. I’m sure we’d have had a great chance of beating Real Madrid at Hampden Park if we could have got to the final. It was a frustrating time for me and a frustrating time for the club but I knew that, with the manager staying, United would push on again next time round. I couldn’t imagine that I wouldn’t be a part of that when it happened. I was in the middle of negotiations over a new contract. I knew what I wanted to do and I was pretty sure I knew what the club wanted to do. Modern-day soccer, though, is never as simple as that. The negotiations, and the newspaper speculation, had already spun on for over a year. Now was the time to set